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REPOSITIONING BUSINESS EDUCATION IN THE DIGITAL AGE: STRATEGIES FOR CURRICULUM AND SKILL DEVELOPMENT AT TERTIARY LEVEL

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Abstract

This paper examined the rapid advancement of digital technologies as it transformed business operations and creates new expectations for educational systems worldwide. Business education, which traditionally focused on developing administrative, managerial, accounting, entrepreneurial, and office competencies, is increasingly required to adapt to the demands of the digital economy. This study examines the repositioning of business education in the digital age with emphasis on strategies for curriculum and skill development. The paper adopts a conceptual and descriptive approach through the review of relevant literature and scholarly discussions on digital transformation and contemporary educational practices. The study highlights the need for curriculum modernization through the integration of digital literacy, artificial intelligence, business analytics, e-commerce, digital marketing, competency-based learning, and technology-enhanced instructional methods. It further emphasizes the importance of developing practical, entrepreneurial, and employability skills such as critical thinking, communication, collaboration, problem-solving, innovation, and adaptability. The study identifies major challenges affecting the repositioning of business education, including inadequate technological infrastructure, insufficient funding, limited digital competence among educators, resistance to change, and weak industry–institution collaboration. The paper concludes that repositioning business education is essential for producing graduates who can compete effectively in modern, technology-driven workplaces and contribute meaningfully to economic development. It recommends continuous curriculum review, investment in digital infrastructure, staff capacity development, stronger industry partnerships, and

the adoption of flexible and inclusive learning systems to enhance business education outcomes in the digital age.

Keywords: Business Education, Digital Age, Curriculum Development, Skill Development, Digital Literacy, Educational Innovation.

Introduction

The twenty-first century has witnessed an unprecedented transformation in the global business landscape, driven largely by digitalization, automation and continuous technological innovation. According to Barrot (2022) and (Thelma et. al. 2024), higher education institutions are under increasing pressure to equip students with the specific knowledge and competencies required to thrive in the digital-driven workplaces. Furthermore, Alsarayreh (2025), noted that business education which has traditionally focused on foundational management, accounting and administrative skills now faces the critical challenges on integrating digital tools and technological literacy. To remain relevant, institutional curricula must evolve beyond traditional boundaries to encompass the contemporary skill.

Jackson (2019), asserts that digitalization has not only transformed business operations but has also fundamentally reshaped the competencies required of modern graduates. Today, students entering the workforce are expected to possess a blend of digital literacy, critical thinking and high levels of adaptability to navigate the complex rapidly changing environments. Consequently, business education must undergo a significant repositioning to align curriculum design, instructional strategies and assessment methods with these digital-age demands. Jackson further warns that a failure to modernize risks producing graduates with skills mismatched to industry requirements, ultimately undermining both student employability and broader organizational productivity.

Ikpesu and Epelle (2023) observed that business education in many higher institutions has historically relied on conventional classroom-based methods with a heavy emphasis on theory and rote learning. While this foundational approach provides essential knowledge, it often fails to equip students with the practical digital competencies required in today's technology-driven markets. The rapid pace of digital transformation now demands that graduates possess a sophisticated blend of managerial expertise, digital literacy and the ability to leverage Information Communication Technology tools effectively, (Bautista, 2026).

Furthermore, Nwachukwu (2024), emphasized that business education plays a critical role in human capital development by preparing students to contribute to both organizational and societal growth through modern structured curricula, students acquire a dual set of competencies:

- a. Hard Skills: Proficiency in accounting software, financial analysis and data management
- b. Soft Skill: Communication, teamwork, leadership and adaptability.

The long-term relevance of the discipline depends heavily on how effectively institutions adapt to global trends such as automation and Artificial Intelligence (AI). As Cheng et. al. (2022) noted

that this evolution serves a broad spectrum of stakeholders, for instance, it secures a pathway to career advancement, it ensures a steady supply of graduates capable of immediate integration into digital workplaces and it bolsters their reputation and contribution to national development. Consequently, repositioning through curriculum innovation is no longer optional, it is a necessity for aligning educational outputs with the digital economy.

Business education in higher institutions is a specialized academic branch designed to equip students with the knowledge, skills and competencies necessary to manage and operate business organizations effectively, (Owhoeke et. al., 2025). This field encompasses diverse disciplines including accounting, finance, marketing, management, secretarial studies and entrepreneurship blending theoretical foundations with practical application to prepare graduates for professional practice in multifaceted environments. Beyond technical proficiency, high-level business education is structured to nurture critical thinking, complex problem-solving and ethical decision-making (Chiedu, 2025). These “soft” yet essential attributes are vital for students to remain resilient and adaptable within increasingly dynamic economic and technological landscapes.

Draft (2017), defined digital skills development as the process of equipping individuals with the knowledge, abilities and competencies necessary to effectively utilize digital technologies in professional, academic and personal contexts. Within the specific domain of business education these skills encompass a broad spectrum of capabilities including foundational computer literacy, proficiency in productivity software, data analysis, digital communication, cyber security awareness and adaptability to emerging technologies, Ferran et. al. (2021). These competencies are essential for students and staff to navigate an increasingly technology driven business environment and remain competitive in the global digital economy.

According to Omeh et. al. (2024), the successful development of these skills is intrinsically linked to curriculum design and pedagogical strategy. They maintained that business education programs must move beyond theory by integrating digital literacy modules, software-based practical exercise and simulations of real-world processes directly into the coursework.

Furthermore, Alenezi (2023) emphasized that digital skills development is not limited to the student body, it extends to academic staff and administrators. Lecturers must be proficient in digital tools for content delivery and virtual assessment while administrators must leverage technology for efficient record-keeping and workflow management. Singum (2025) warns that inadequate digital skills among staff can hinder curriculum delivery, reduce student engagement and ultimately limit the benefits of institutional digitalization.

Ultimately, digital skill development enhances employability, productivity and innovation. Graduate with strong digital competencies are better equipped to solve complex business problem business problems, collaborate in virtual teams and interpret data to make informed decisions (Reaves, 2019).

Heynia (2025) defined employability as the capacity of graduates to acquire, maintain and excel in employment by possessing the specific knowledge, attitudes and competencies demanded by the modern workplace. Beyond academic qualifications, employability encompasses practical problem-solving, digital literacy, adaptability and professional behaviours that enable effective

performance in dynamic business environments, Onyeka and City, (2023). Closely related is workforce readiness which emphasizes the seamless transition of graduates into professional roles, their ability to contribute to organizational objectives and their capacity to adapt to evolving technological demands.

The integration of digital skills and curriculum innovation directly impacts these outcomes. In the digital era, employers expect core business knowledge to be paired with proficiency in digital tools and virtual collaboration. For instance, graduates capable of analyzing data through specialized software, executing digital marketing campaigns or navigating enterprise resource planning systems are significantly more attractive to technology-driven organization (Alessi, 2024).

Nyaope (2025) noted that higher institutions play a pivotal role in shaping these outcomes by aligning curriculum content with industrial requirements and promoting experiential learning.

Digitalization enhances this alignment through:

- a. Online simulation that is replicating complex business decisions;
- b. Virtual internships that is providing global professional exposure; and
- c. Technology-mediated learning that is mirroring real-world remote work scenarios.

This approach does more than provide technical competency; it develops the critical thinking and decision-making abilities essential for modern professional life by integrating these elements higher institutions most ensure that graduates are not only academically competent but also professionally prepared to adapt to a rapidly evolving landscape. This alignment reinforces the study's central goal: repositioning business education to produce a capable, competitive and "future-proof" workforce.

The Technology Acceptance Model (TAM), developed by Davis (1989), is highly relevant to understanding the repositioning of business education in the digital age because it explains how lecturers and students accept and utilize digital technologies that are essential for curriculum and skill development. The model posits that two key factors—perceived usefulness and perceived ease of use determine individuals' intention to adopt technology. In relation to business education, perceived usefulness refers to the extent to which lecturers and students believe that digital tools such as learning management systems, accounting software, data analytics platforms, and virtual collaboration tools will enhance teaching effectiveness, learning outcomes, and employability skills, while perceived ease of use refers to how simple and manageable these technologies are perceived to be in classroom instruction and learning processes. When applied to curriculum repositioning, TAM explains that successful integration of digital literacy, e-learning platforms, and technology-based instruction depends not only on availability of infrastructure but also on users' positive beliefs about the benefits and usability of these tools. If educators perceive digital technologies as improving curriculum delivery and making skill acquisition more practical and relevant to industry demands, they are more likely to integrate them into teaching practices, thereby strengthening students' digital competencies. Conversely, resistance, poor adoption, or ineffective implementation of curriculum innovations may occur when users perceive digital tools as complex, time-consuming, or irrelevant to learning objectives. Therefore, TAM provides a strong theoretical foundation for this study by highlighting that repositioning business education through curriculum

modernization and skill development requires not only technological provision but also user acceptance, training, and continuous support to ensure effective adoption and sustainable digital transformation.

Empirical research consistently demonstrates how digitalization, curriculum innovation and digital skills development directly influence business education outcomes. Recent studies emphasized that integrating technology into the curriculum is no longer an elective enhancement but a core requirement for workforce readiness.

A study by Jimoh (2025) examined digital literacy, academic performance and skill acquisition among business education students in Kaduna State, Nigeria. The findings revealed that students with higher digital competence were significantly more employable and better prepared for modern workplace demand. Conversely, the study identified that curriculum gaps and inadequate exposure to technology-based learning negatively impacted student's readiness for the digital economy.

In a related study, Dorgu (2020), investigated curriculum innovation in Nigerian institutions, reporting that Universities incorporating digital learning tools, simulations and technology enhanced teaching produced graduates with superior practical skills and higher workforce adaptability. Similarly, Yadav (2024), posited that digitalization promotes active engagement and develops skills that are directly transferable to professional contexts.

Beyond student outcomes, research highlights the critical role of institutional support. Martinez (2025), demonstrated that student's digital competencies serve as a "mediating variable" between technology-supported environments and workforce preparedness. This suggest that providing tools is insufficient, they must be paired with a structured and integrated into effective curriculum.

Business Education in the Digital Age

Business education in the digital age is the transformation of business teaching and learning through the integration of digital technologies, modern instructional approaches, and contemporary workplace competencies, Fleaca et. al. (2019). They further stated that unlike traditional business education, which focused mainly on accounting, office practice, marketing, and administrative functions, digital-era business education prepares learners to operate effectively in technology-driven business environments. It equips students with both business knowledge and digital capabilities required for participation in modern economies.

Mahmood et. al. (2024), stated that the emergence of technologies such as artificial intelligence, cloud computing, data analytics, virtual communication tools, and e-commerce has significantly influenced the structure and delivery of business education. In their assertion Akintayo, et. al. (2024), stated that educational institutions are increasingly adopting digital platforms, online learning systems, and technology-supported teaching methods to enhance learning experiences and improve accessibility. They further stated that this shift enables students to learn more flexibly while gaining exposure to real-world digital business practices.

AlDhaen, (2023), informed that a major characteristic of business education in the digital age is its emphasis on competency and skill acquisition and that modern business programmes focus not

only on theoretical understanding but also on practical abilities such as digital literacy, critical thinking, problem-solving, communication, collaboration, and data management. Alsarayreh, (2025), opined that students are expected to develop the capacity to apply business concepts using modern technologies and adapt to changing workplace conditions.

Mugunzva (2024), informed that business education in the digital era also promotes innovation and entrepreneurship, through exposure to digital business models and emerging technologies and that students are encouraged to develop entrepreneurial mindsets and create business opportunities in areas such as online commerce, digital services, and technology-enabled enterprises. He further informed that this approach enhances employability and supports self-reliance in increasingly competitive labour markets.

Overall, business education in the digital age represents a strategic response to changes in the global business environment. By integrating technology into curriculum delivery and emphasizing relevant skills development, business education would become more responsive to labour market demands and better positioned to prepare graduates for success in the digital economy.

Challenges to Repositioning Business Education in the Digital Age

Mamman et. al. (2025), asserted that one of the major challenges to repositioning business education in the digital age is inadequate technological infrastructure. Effective implementation of digital business education requires reliable internet access, modern computer laboratories, digital learning platforms, electricity supply, and access to current educational technologies. Abuali et. al. (2025), informed that in many institutions, especially in developing economies, limited infrastructure restricts the integration of technology into teaching and learning. This limitation affects curriculum implementation and reduces students' opportunities to develop practical digital competencies required in modern workplaces.

Another significant challenge as identified by Nyale et. al., (2026), is insufficient funding and financial constraints. Repositioning business education through curriculum innovation and skill development demands substantial investment in technological facilities, software applications, staff training, and digital resources. They further stated that many educational institutions operate under limited budgets, making it difficult to acquire and maintain digital infrastructure or support continuous curriculum reform. Without adequate financial support, efforts to modernize business education may not achieve sustainable outcomes.

A further challenge is the digital skills gap among educators and students. Loisulie et. al. (2025) informed that many instructors may lack adequate knowledge and confidence in the use of emerging technologies for teaching and assessment. Similarly, Upadhyaya (2024), was of the view that students entering business education programmes may possess varying levels of digital competence, creating disparities in learning outcomes. Therefore, when educators are not sufficiently prepared to deliver technology-driven instruction, the effectiveness of curriculum transformation and skill acquisition becomes limited.

Barslund et. al. (2025), observed that the challenge of limited industry collaboration and weak linkage between education and labour market needs also affects repositioning efforts. They further

observed that in some cases, business education curricula are developed without adequate consultation with employers, professional bodies, and industry experts. This disconnect may produce graduates whose skills do not align with workplace expectations. Therefore, strong partnerships are necessary to ensure practical exposure, curriculum relevance, and continuous improvement of training programmes.

Strategies for Curriculum and Skill Development

Curriculum Modernization and Continuous Review

One major strategy for repositioning business education in the digital age is curriculum modernization and continuous review. Gilic (2026), stated that business education curricula should be updated regularly to reflect changes in technology, industry practices, and labour market expectations and that traditional course contents should be expanded to include emerging areas such as artificial intelligence, digital marketing, business analytics, e-commerce, cloud computing, financial technology, cybersecurity awareness, and digital entrepreneurship. A modern curriculum ensures that students acquire knowledge and competencies that are relevant to contemporary business environments.

Integration of Digital Literacy and Technology-Based Learning

Another important strategy is the integration of digital literacy and technology-based learning across all business education programmes. Digital competence should no longer be treated as an optional skill but as a core component of learning outcomes, as stated by (Papazoglou, 2026). They further stated that students should be trained in the use of business software, online collaboration tools, data management systems, virtual communication platforms, and digital information resources and that educators should also adopt technology-enhanced instructional methods such as blended learning, virtual classrooms, online assessments, and interactive learning platforms to improve student engagement and learning effectiveness.

Competency-Based and Experiential Learning Approaches

Chad (2025), stated that the adoption of competency-based and experiential learning approaches is also essential for curriculum and skill development. Business education should focus on developing practical competencies rather than emphasizing theoretical knowledge alone. Teaching strategies should include case studies, simulations, project-based learning, business incubation activities, internships, industrial attachments, and real-life business problem-solving experiences. These approaches enable students to apply knowledge in practical settings and develop workplace readiness.

Strengthening Industry–Institution Collaboration and Interdisciplinary Learning

Another strategy involves strengthening industry–institution collaboration and interdisciplinary learning. Kayyali (2025), was of the view that educational institutions should establish partnerships with industries, professional bodies, and technology organizations to ensure that

curricula align with current business realities. He further asserted that industry experts can contribute to curriculum development, mentorship programmes, internship opportunities, and practical training. In addition, integrating concepts from information technology, entrepreneurship, innovation studies, and management can help produce graduates with broader and more adaptable competencies.

Development of Employability and Soft Skills

Equally important is the development of employability and soft skills required in modern business environments. Elkhayma and Ezzaidi (2025), maintained that beyond technical competence, business education should intentionally develop communication skills, leadership ability, teamwork, critical thinking, creativity, emotional intelligence, adaptability, and decision-making capacity. These skills improve graduates' effectiveness in both physical and virtual workplaces and enable them to respond successfully to changing professional demands.

Lifelong Learning and Continuous Professional Development

Ali (2025), stated that promoting lifelong learning and continuous professional development is necessary for sustainable skill development. He further stated that the rapid pace of technological advancement means that knowledge and skills quickly become outdated. Business education institutions should encourage students and educators to embrace continuous learning through professional training, digital certification programmes, online courses, research activities, and regular upskilling initiatives. This strategy ensures that graduates remain relevant, competitive, and capable of contributing meaningfully to the digital economy.

Conclusion

This study concludes that repositioning business education for the digital age requires a strategic convergence of institutional information and communication technology support, curriculum innovation and digital skills development. Higher institutions offering business education must proactively invest in digital infrastructure, provide widespread technology access and prioritize faculty training in information and communication technology to ensure that business education programme remains relevant within rapidly evolving global economic and technological landscape.

Suggestions

The following recommendations are proposed to effectively reposition business education for the digital age:

1. To effectively reposition business education in the digital age, educational institutions should prioritize continuous curriculum review and modernization. Business education curricula should be revised regularly to reflect current technological developments and labour market demands. Emerging areas such as artificial intelligence, digital marketing, business analytics, e-commerce, cloud technologies, and digital entrepreneurship should be incorporated into

academic programmes. Curriculum development should also emphasize practical application and competency acquisition to ensure that graduates possess relevant and employable skills, Hao, (2024).

2. There is also a need for greater investment in digital infrastructure and capacity building. Governments, institutional administrators, and relevant stakeholders should provide adequate funding for internet connectivity, digital learning platforms, computer laboratories, software resources, and uninterrupted power supply. In addition, continuous training and professional development programmes should be organized for educators to strengthen their digital teaching competencies and improve the quality of technology-supported instruction.
3. Educational institutions should further promote industry collaboration and experiential learning opportunities. Partnerships with industries, professional associations, and technology organizations can support curriculum improvement and expose students to real workplace experiences. Internship programmes, industrial attachments, mentorship initiatives, business simulations, and project-based learning should become integral components of business education to strengthen practical competence and improve graduate employability.
4. There is also a need to develop strong institutional policies that support digital transformation in education. Policies should guide curriculum implementation, technology integration, digital ethics, data protection, quality assurance, and continuous monitoring of educational outcomes. Clear institutional frameworks can promote consistency and sustainability in repositioning efforts.
5. Finally, institutions should encourage lifelong learning, innovation, and inclusive access to digital education. Students and educators should be motivated to continuously update their knowledge and skills through certification programmes, online learning opportunities, research activities, and professional training. Efforts should also be made to ensure equal access to digital resources so that all learners can benefit from modern educational practices and contribute meaningfully to economic and societal development in the digital age.

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